

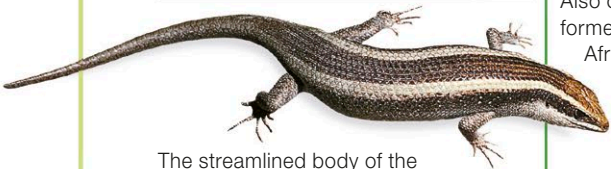
Trachylepis striata

African striped skink



Length 7–10 in (18–25 cm)
Breeding Viviparous
Habit Mostly terrestrial
Status Not evaluated

Location E. and southern Africa



The streamlined body of the African striped skink is highly variable in color, but is often brown, with paler stripes running along the back. It has a pointed head, smooth, shiny scales, and transparent “windows” on its lower eyelids. Males of some populations have an orange head and a yellowish orange throat. This skink lives in a wide variety of habitats, from mangrove swamps to arid areas, and is sometimes found in high densities. Very active during the day, it climbs into shrubs and trees, rocky outcrops, and buildings in search of prey such as small insects and spiders, stopping frequently to bask. When attacked, it can shed its tail. Females give birth to 3–9 young, each about 2¼–3¼ in (6–8 cm) long, which take 15–18 months to mature.

Lepidothyris fernandi

African fire skink

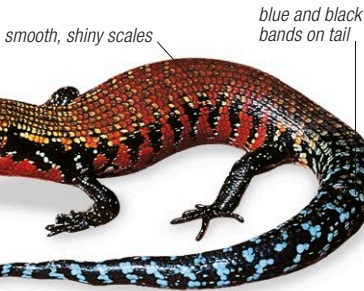


Length 9–14½ in (22–37 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Not evaluated

Location W. and C. Africa



Also called the fire-sided skink, and formerly known as *Riopa fernandi*, the African fire skink has a short head and stocky body with a brown back, red and black bands on the flanks and face, and blue and black bands on its tail. It lives among leaf litter, and is active at twilight, when it forages for insects and spiders. Like many other lizards, this skink can shed its tail when attacked by a snake or other predator. The female lays up to 8 eggs in leaf litter or rotting wood. Since the African fire skink is rarely seen in the wild, most information comes from observations of captive animals.



Tiliqua rugosa

Stump-tailed skink

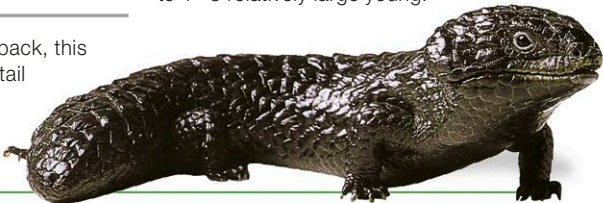


Length 12–14 in (30–35 cm)
Breeding Viviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Not evaluated

Location S. and W. Australia



Also known as the shingleback, this skink has a short, stumpy tail that looks like a pinecone, and enlarged, raised dorsal scales. The thick



tail acts as a food-storage organ, while the heavily armored body provides protection. Coloration is variable, ranging from dark brown to cream, sometimes with light or dark spots. This slow-moving, omnivorous lizard rests under logs or in leaf litter, and is an active forager. It is temporarily monogamous: pairs remain together for about 8 weeks in the breeding season, then separate, often reuniting the following year. Females give birth to 1–3 relatively large young.

Tiliqua gigas

Giant blue-tongued skink

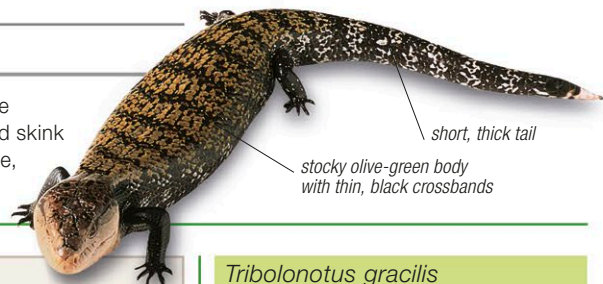


Length 20–24 in (50–62 cm)
Breeding Viviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Not evaluated

Location S.E. Asia, New Guinea and satellite islands



A close relative of the eastern blue-tongued skink (see below), this large, New Guinean lizard



uses the same defensive technique, displaying its startlingly blue tongue to ward off attack. If this fails, it may bite. This skink constantly pokes its snout about in leaf litter, actively foraging and scavenging for insects, mollusks, fruit, and leaves. It lives in colonies believed to consist of a dominant male and several females and juveniles. Females produce 8–13 young, which often remain close to their mother for the first few days, possibly weeks.

Tiliqua scincoides

Eastern blue-tongued skink



Length 18–20 in (45–50 cm)
Breeding Viviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Not evaluated

Location N., E., and S.E. Australia



This large, slow-moving animal is one of Australia’s most familiar reptiles. It lives in a wide variety of habitats, and is often seen on roads, where its stubby shape and camouflage coloring make it look like a piece of fallen wood. The eastern blue-tongued skink has a wide-ranging diet, and actively forages for snails, insects, carrion, flowers, fruit, and berries; it will even scavenge for leftovers at picnic sites. During the breeding season, males are territorial; mating takes place after a brief chase, at the end of which the male bites the female on the back of the head. The female gives birth to up to 25 young per litter, following a gestation period of about

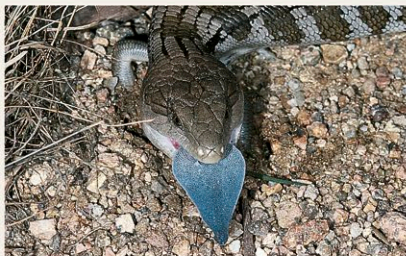


PHYSICAL APPEARANCE
The eastern blue-tongued skink is a bulky reptile, with a wide head, thickset body, and relatively short limbs. Light gray or brown above, it has irregular, dark brown crossbars on the body and tail.

150 days. The young take about 3 years to reach maturity. This skink can live for up to 25 years in captivity. Several similar species of skink live in Australia, one of them also occurring in New Guinea and Sumatra.

DEFENSIVE DISPLAY

The eastern blue-tongued skink gets its name from its large, bright blue tongue, which it rolls out of its mouth when threatened. Combined with loud hissing, this visual display is often enough to ward off an attack. This skink is generally harmless, although it has a powerful—if toothless—bite.



Tribolonotus gracilis

Crocodile skink



Length 6–8 in (15–20 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Least concern

Location New Guinea



The crocodile skink has a bony, triangular head, 4 rows of spines on the back and tail, and orange, glasseslike rings around its eyes. The glands present on the soles of its feet and on the abdomen are believed to be associated with scent secretion and communication. It is slow-moving and secretive, hiding in leaf litter and debris. If disturbed, it gives out a loud screech. The male usually lives with one or more females, which lay one very large egg in leaf litter or other rotting plant matter.

